

CATCH YA ON THE FLIPSIDE

The courtroom was old.

Wood everywhere. Dark panels lining the walls, worn smooth by decades of hands and shoulders leaning against them. The kind of building that was built to intimidate—to make you feel small standing in it. The carpet was new, though. Someone's attempt at modernisation that only made the rest of it look older. Like putting fresh paint on a coffin.

I'd been in rooms like this before. Plenty of times. But always for the smaller stuff—the appearances, the adjournments, the legal theatre that happens before anything real gets decided. This was different.

This was sentencing.

Kate was already at the defence table when they brought me in.

Pencil skirt. White blouse. Heels that clicked on the floor when she walked. Young—couldn't have been more than a few years older than me—but she carried herself like she'd been doing this for decades. You had to, I suppose. Criminal defence isn't a job for people who flinch.

We knew each other well by now. Too well, probably. She could pick me out from behind in a crowded courthouse. Not the kind of connection you brag about, but it was there.

The prosecutor sat on the other side of the room. Police badge. Stack of folders. The look of someone who'd already decided how this should end.

And me—I was in the box. Defendant's dock. Positioned between the judge's bench and Kate's table like I was the fulcrum the whole room balanced on.

The gallery was sparse.

A few randoms waiting for their own cases to be called. And then my people—my brother, who'd wagged school to be there. Si. Stacey.

They weren't looking at me. Not directly. You don't stare in courtrooms—you glance. Quick looks when the attention is elsewhere. A kind of silent communication that exists between people who know each other too well to need words.

My brother was fifteen. Just a kid, really—though he wouldn't have agreed with that description. He sat with that particular stillness teenagers have when they're trying to look older than they are. Trying to be steady for me, maybe. Or just trying to understand what was happening.

Si had that expression he always wore when shit got serious—half smirk, half something else. The look of someone who knew the score but was still hoping for a different outcome.

Stacey just sat there. Quiet. Watching. The kind of watching that says everything words can't.

The judge spoke.

I don't remember all of it. The legal language that fills these rooms—it washes over you after a while. You catch the words that matter and let the rest blur into background noise.

Eighteen charges.

That part I remember. Grand theft auto. Cultivation with intent. Burglary. The list went on, each one adding weight to the air in the room.

Two years. Five years. Six years.

The numbers started stacking. I was doing the maths in my head—the way you do when someone's talking about your life in numbers. Adding. Calculating. Watching the total climb.

At four years, something in my chest tightened. Not panic—I don't do panic. Just... acknowledgment. Recognition of how deep this hole was getting.

This is not fucking good.

I didn't let it show. Kept my face empty. Eyes on the judge. Stacey was in my peripheral vision—I could see her expression shifting, the worry settling in, the kind of concern that makes you want to look away. I didn't look. Held the line.

The judge kept reading.

When he finished with the charges, he paused.

Looked at me over his glasses. The way teachers look at students who've disappointed them.

Then he started talking about me.

My offending history. My age. The pattern. The trajectory. A stranger in robes telling me who I was based on paper. Based on dates and charges and whatever Kate had managed to say in my defence.

I stood there and took it.

Just another day at the office.

The bailiffs were already moving before he finished.

That's how you know it's done. The uniforms shift. The energy in the room changes. Everyone starts preparing for the next part—the part where you stop being a defendant and start being a number.

I looked at the gallery.

My brother. Fifteen years old. Wagging school to watch his older brother get sent down. I mouthed the words at him:

Catch ya on the flipside.

Si. My best mate. Sitting there with that expression he always had when shit got serious—half smirk, half something else.

Peace out, ballbag.

Stacey. I didn't have words for her. Just the look. The one that says *I'll be alright* even when you're not sure that's true.

I raised my hand. Casual military salute. The kind that says goodbye without making it heavy.

Then I turned and walked.

The bailiff's hand on my elbow wasn't rough. Just firm. Guiding.

The door closed behind me with a sound like a walk-in chiller sealing shut.

* * *

The room on the other side was small.

Maybe two and a half metres wide. Three and a half deep. A desk stretched across the width of it, bolted to the floor—because apparently even furniture couldn't be trusted in here. The walls were the same bureaucratic beige as every other government building I'd ever been dragged through.

Three doors.

The one behind me led back to the courtroom. The one to my left led down to the basement—the holding cells, custody, the place you go when you're no longer a person with a name but a body with a case number. The one in front of me, on the other side of the desk, was where Kate would come through.

I sat down.

The chair wasn't bolted, which felt like a small victory.

Fifteen minutes.

That's how long I waited. Felt longer. Time moves differently when you've just heard years attached to your name and you're sitting in a room designed to make you feel like cargo.

The internal monologue wasn't much.

You've gone and fucked this one up.

That was about it. No spiralling. No bargaining. Just acknowledgment. The same way you'd note you'd burnt a pan or missed a turn. Statement of fact. File it away. Move on.

I stared at the desk. Counted the scratches in the surface. Wondered how many other people had sat in this exact chair, waiting for their lawyer to walk through that door and tell them what came next.

The door opened.

Kate walked in with a stack of folders under her arm and a look on her face that didn't match the situation. Pleased with herself. The kind of expression you have when you've just talked your way out of a parking ticket—not when your client's just been sentenced.

She sat down across from me. Found my folder in the stack without hesitation. Started pulling paperwork.

I watched her for a second.

"What the fuck are you so happy about?"

Not angry. More confused. A half-laugh underneath it. The kind of tone you use when you think you've missed something—or when someone's about to make a joke at your expense.

She looked up. That smile still there.

"You got concurrent sentencing."

She said it like it was obvious. Like I should've been celebrating already.

"Concurrent?"

"Mm-hmm."

She went back to the paperwork. Legal aid forms. Fee schedules. The administrative shit that follows you even into a holding room.

I sat there.

Concurrent.

The word rattled around in my head, bumping into things, not quite landing. I'd heard it before. Thought I knew what it meant. But standing in that courtroom, watching the years stack up—two, five, six—I'd been doing the maths one way. Adding. Stacking. *Consecutive*. That was the word I'd been thinking of.

"Wait."

Kate looked up.

"Is concurrent the good one?"

She paused. Just for a second. Then the smile widened into something almost like a laugh.

"Sure is."

The relief didn't hit the way you'd expect.

No flood of emotion. No weight lifting off my shoulders. Just a recalculation. A reframing. The numbers rearranging themselves into something survivable.

"Fuck yes."

Then the next thought:

"Wait—so how long then?"

Kate set down her pen.

"A year. Maybe less. I'm pushing for home detention at the six-week mark."

A year.

Not six.

Not eight.

One.

"Fuck yes, ya good bitch."

She laughed. Actual laughter—the kind that breaks through the professional mask for a second.

"Not a problem. That's what I'm here for."

She slid the paperwork across the desk.

Legal aid forms. Consent documents. The usual stack that follows every court appearance like a paper trail of your own bad decisions.

I didn't read any of it.

Kate was my lawyer. Reading the paperwork was her job. If she said sign, I signed. That was the deal. Now, if it had been paperwork from the cops—that was different. I'd read every word, then hand it to Kate to read again before I put my name anywhere near it.

Trust calibrated by experience.

I signed where she pointed. Initialled where she indicated. Let the pen move without thinking too hard about what I was agreeing to.

"The home detention," Kate said, gathering up the forms. "Don't get your hopes up."

"Yeah?"

"You've breached every bail condition you've ever been given. Some of them multiple times. The board's going to look at that."

I nodded.

She wasn't wrong. My history with conditions was shit. Every time they'd given me a leash, I'd found a way to slip it. Not because I was trying to make a point—just because that's how I operated. Rules were suggestions. Boundaries were challenges.

That doesn't play well at parole hearings.

"Worth a shot though," she said. "We'll see."

I didn't tell Stacey about the home detention possibility.

Not that day. Not for weeks. I waited until about a week before the hearing, and even then I kept it vague. *There's a thing coming up. Might mean something, might not. Don't get excited.*

Protecting her from hope that might collapse. The same way I'd protected myself in that courtroom—armour up, expect the worst, let the good news be a surprise if it comes.

It didn't come.

But we'll get to that.

In that moment—sitting across from Kate in the holding room, paperwork signed, the word *concurrent* finally meaning what it was supposed to mean—I let myself feel something.

Not relief exactly.

More like... recalibration.

One year.

I could do one year.

I'd been through worse.

... Or had I?